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Bobby Gordon

Bobby Gordon was born in 1942 in Hartford, Connecticut, and was raised on Long Island. He benefited from a close relationship with clarinetist Joe Marsala and he honed his own clarinet skills with Muggsy Spanier, Louis Armstrong and Wild Bill Davison after moving to Chicago. In the 60s and 70s, Bobby played with the Jim Cullum Band, Warren Vache and Max Kaminsky. He has performed with Leon Redbone, Keith Ingham, and Rebecca Kilgore, and he recently released "Bobby Gordon Plays Bing" on Arbors Records. He currently resides in San Diego.

Bobby was interviewed at the Allegheny Jazz Party in Chautauqua, New York on September 12, 1997 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe. We are interviewing today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and it's a pleasure to host Bobby Gordon, clarinetist. Welcome to Chautauqua.

BG: Thank you very much.

MR: You had a long flight from San Diego. How long have you been in San Diego?

BG: I've been living in San Diego now for about the last seventeen years. I'm from New York City originally, and Long Island, Manhasset, Long Island, by way of New York City. And then I've been out in San Diego now for about seventeen years.

MR: You can probably actually look at me which is okay. We have a camera right there too. What's the West Coast jazz scene like in San Diego? Do you have to travel to play?

BG: Well there's a lot of festivals in California. There's a festival every week if you really wanted to work that hard — all the way from San Diego I would say up to Seattle and Washington, Portland, Oregon, all the way across Utah, Nevada. You could work every weekend, you could play every weekend at a jazz festival if you wanted to, 52 weeks a year.

MR: Do you want to?

BG: Well it depends on the type they are, and the type of bands that they have. Usually what I do is I travel, I make San Diego my base and I travel out of town, sort of do this type of a thing and things like that.

MR: In the book we were just talking about, the recent jazz recording book, it describes you as a Dixieland, swing clarinetist. Is that a fair statement?

BG: I would say that was very nice of them to say that. I'm proud of that, being a Dixieland and swing clarinet player.

MR: How has Dixieland — this could be a hard question, but we'll try it — how has Dixieland music changed from, I don't know, its New Orleans heritage?

BG: Well it's changed quite a bit. In the old days, I guess in New Orleans in the 1920s and even before that, they called it Dixieland jazz and they had mostly blacks playing that

type of music. And now, in the 90s now they have a whole different type of combinations of Dixieland bands. The name "Dixieland" is really a bad term because it puts a label on the type of music that actually was played. Actually it's called "classic jazz" or "traditional jazz," that's what I like to call it. And back in the 20s when they had Johnny Dodds and Louis Armstrong and oh — Jimmy Noone, Mancy Carr, Lillie Delk Christian, Earl Hines, all these different stars in jazz in the 20s, were black artists. And they all sold millions of records. Louis Armstrong sold a million records in 1926 of his "Hot Five" and "Hot Seven" records. And through the years it has evolved, in Chicago, in New York, where more white musicians were getting into it now, getting into it then. I'm speaking of people like Bix Beiderbecke or Bud Freeman, Pee Wee Russell, Eddie Condon — there's a whole slew of them which were called the Chicago style jazz. And these fellows were mostly white guys that heard Louis Armstrong and Johnny Dodds and all these people on riverboats as they traveled up the Mississippi River. And then from there, Eddie Condon, as I was saying before, Eddie Condon, Pee Wee Russell and Bud Freeman etcetera, they moved east to New York and in doing so, they brought in another flux of musicians, where the blacks started to come back in jazz very, very much so — like Fats Waller and James P. Johnson and oh, Art Tatum or anybody like that would come in. And then in the 60s, all these fellows that were playing that jazz in New Orleans and playing the jazz in Chicago were all dying off. And so in the middle 60s there were some people that decided to keep the jazz going. Now some of the people that are keeping it going are here today, I mean at this jazz festival. And one of the major outlets of the white, the older white jazz coming into the younger style of white jazz or black jazz or whatever you want to call it, is Marty Grosz, who is one of our contemporaries, and I've known him since when I was living in Chicago. And there was a few fellows like him — Marty Grosz, Frank Chace, Frank Orchard, Tut Soper, there was Little Brother Montgomery, there was Bob Skiver, there was a whole bunch of different guys that started — the revivalist guys that started bringing that Chicago style back and the New Orleans style back. And then just as they were moved into the 80s, they were getting a little bit older like myself, and Marty Grosz and guys like that, and then there was another influx of musicians who came around again on the younger side. Now the people that are playing jazz today in their 20s and 30s are keeping the flame so to speak, of keeping it alive throughout the 20s, you know, 20s through the 80s. And a lot of those guys are there today at this festival also.

MR: It's great to see young guys doing what I guess, what would we call — sometimes we don't want to put a label on everything — but what we'll hear tonight at this festival. Do you have a name for the style?

BG: No. It's a whole mixture of different styles. You'll hear Dave McKenna on piano solos, whose style, you wouldn't call him a Dixieland piano player or a traditional piano player;

and you have Becky Kilgore, and she's a great singer, and you wouldn't call her traditional or anything like that, she takes more after the Ella Fitzgerald or Lee Wiley type of singing. And some of the bands will not be really Dixieland bands, they'll be sort of like classic jazz bands.

MR: Do you, when we look at the players that are playing this kind of music today, it seems to be rare to see a black musician, a young black musician playing this kind of music. Do you have any thoughts on that?

BG: Well there is, if you go down to New Orleans now there's a few of them that are coming back and playing this type of music. Wallace Davenport and Wendell Brunious, and a few others, Wynton Marsallis and his brother are playing or taking up, the young blacks are coming back again with jazz more in the forefront.

MR: Well that was actually a great answer. I'm glad I asked the question. It sounds like you know your history. Was clarinet your first instrument?

BG: Yes.

MR: And how did you get your start in the world of music?

BG: Well when I was eleven or twelve years old I had a very close friend of my family, his name was Joe Marsala, who was a clarinetist in his own right, he had his own band on 52nd Street, and played with Wingy Manone, played with Louis Prima, played with all of — Bobby Hackett, Eddie Condon, played with all the great bands and he kind of took me under his wing and started giving me clarinet lessons. I asked to have them and it was a good experience because I would go out on location to jobs with him when he used to go to play in New York City. He'd take me on the train and we'd ride in and I got a chance to meet Pee Wee Russell and I got a chance to meet Eddie Condon and George Wettling and Muggsy Spanier and all these people.

MR: That's pretty fascinating for a young man.

BG: Yeah. Well I was about twelve or thirteen years old at the time and it was really something else, really something to see.

MR: Was that the heyday of 52nd Street?

BG: No, 52nd was a little bit before that, but this was after 52nd Street.

MR: And how long did you stay in New York?

BG: Oh, I stayed in New York up until the time I was, around 38 or 39 and then I moved back out to the coast.

MR: When did you think that you were going to be a musician?

BG: Well my dad used to take me down — I'm from Hartford, Connecticut originally, and my dad used to take me down to the State Theatre, which was an old dance place and they showed movies and they had dance bands there. And I saw Joe Marsala play and that brought my interest in the music. I was about four or five years old at the time. And I

used to listen to records, and my dad was in the record business in Hartford and New York, and also in the publishing business, so it was kind of instilled in me and my family, to like music.

MR: So your association with Joe was directly responsible for your picking up the clarinet?

BG: Yes.

MR: And did you get instruction in public school?

BG: Yes I did. In public school and then I went for a couple of years to college, and then learned a little bit about harmony and theory and things like that.

MR: Shall we pause for a minute, Tim? First we had someone pounding on a porch over here. Marty is a great character.

BG: Did you talk to him?

MR: We've talked to him.

BG: Yeah, he's a character.

MR: He was cracking me up. Come on you can do it.

[pause]

MR: Okay, I'll just pick up. What was your experience in public schools as far as your clarinet playing?

BG: Well I started before I was in high school, I started when I was around eleven or twelve years old, and then we had the usual band and orchestra you had to have in high school, and then we had little groups that would come out of that, different guys wanted to get into jazz and things like that back at that time, and so did I. And my friends I'd known through school, we'd form little groups and play for dances and little parties and things like that, and then we had the regular band and orchestra. And I didn't take any instruction in high school, mostly through Joe Marsala, who taught me a great knowledge of chords and a great knowledge of trying to improvise on certain chord progressions. So that's really where I got my basic start, from Joe Marsala.

MR: When you were playing for these school dances and so forth, what year was that, what years?

BG: Well these were 1957 and 1958, '56 around there.

MR: So the popular music of that time, they were leaning towards rock & roll.

BG: Well that's when Elvis Presley came out, around that time. And he kind of changed everything for musicians and jazz musicians especially. Because everybody started to like rock & roll then, and that type of music. Our type of music went in the background, and it still hasn't come back yet, but it's starting to come through a little bit now I think.

MR: So what kind of music would you play for school dances?

BG: Well around that time there was a movie that came out called "The Benny Goodman Story" with Steve Allen and Donna Reed. And we used to play the Benny Goodman

tunes, you know, and things like that. And we played in the theatre for the original opening of the movie, in Manhasset, Long Island, just a trio — piano, drums and clarinet. And then we'd still play the old style of jazz, but we wouldn't play any rock & roll. We were kind of against that. We were rebelling against that.

MR: You were taking a stand. That's interesting. Well I'm interested in how Joe taught you chords and so forth. Did he play a keyboard instrument or did he just talk about it?

BG: No he just talked to me about it and played the clarinet and showed me certain things. I memorized a lot of the stuff that he told me and later on it came out. When I went to the University of California in San Diego and I knew exactly what they were talking about when I was studying music, because I had that instilled in me at an earlier age, about chord progressions and scales and writing and things like that. I knew how to do that way before I was in high school and way before I was in college. Because just by listening to records and listening to Louis Armstrong and listening to Eddie Condon and certain guys, Pee Wee Russell and Joe Marsala, I used to listen to records constantly, and then also got a chance, like I said, to go on the train into New York City and meet these great jazz musicians with Joe. Jack Teagarden, you name them, you can just name them just like that, off the bat, they were great. And they were always very nice to me and I looked up to them. And I always said I always wanted to be a jazz musicians like these guys. And I thought they were very successful, you know, and I said, well this is what I want to do.

MR: Would you do it all over again?

BG: Yes I think I would, yeah.

MR: I'm glad to hear that. It is a kind of, it looks like a glamorous thing to do at the time.

BG: At the time, yeah. You say well these guys look so sharp, and where do they get all this money?

MR: Did you ever have to work non-musical jobs?

BG: A few times I did, yes.

MR: I think most musicians end up doing some of that, they may not talk about it an awful lot. When was the first — do you have a gig or a series of gigs with a certain person that you felt was really your entrance into let's say the big time or really doing what you wanted to?

BG: Well what I'm doing now is what I really enjoy. I've never enjoyed anything so much because I'm getting a chance to play with musicians that are great New York musicians, and as I say again, a lot of them are here today: Scott Robinson, Marty Grosz, Keith Ingham, Hal Smith. Just in the last ten or fifteen years I've been getting into that type of music and being lucky enough to make a lot of recordings with Marty and do a lot of appearances. I've been to Japan twice. I'd say this is the most musical feeling I've had, the best musical experience I've had for a long time. But years ago I used to play with

Muggsy Spanier and I played with Eddie Condon and Bobby Hackett and Jimmy McPartland. That was just little stints, eight weeks here, maybe sixteen weeks there, three weeks there. But now that I'm doing a lot of recordings with Marty and we have a little group called The Orphan Newsboys, I'm really at my happiest experiences right now.

MR: Tell me a little bit about your experience with Eddie Condon.

BG: Well I didn't know him very well but he was a very close friend of my father's Eddie was. And I knew Eddie later on in life, just before he passed away. And I just started to work with him just before his death. I was working maybe a year or two before. I was working with him in New York City and I even asked him, I said, "Eddie I have a job, would you like to come out and play" and I called him up and he said sure he would. And we were all on cloud nine because Eddie Condon's going to come out and play with us. But I didn't know him that well but I appeared with him a couple of times, many times, but I didn't know him that well.

MR: And didn't you go on to play in Condon's?

BG: Eddie Condon's — I did Eddie Condon's club in 1978, I was the house clarinet player there for three years.

MR: Now what does it mean, perhaps we'll have some people watching this that may not know what it means to be a "house clarinetist."

BG: Well a house clarinet player is the regular clarinet player that's there every night, in and out, no matter who's there you have to be there six nights a week, and you play from nine 'til two in the morning or eight-thirty to one-thirty or whatever it is. But I was there for three years. The house clarinet player means just what it is, you're the clarinet player for the club and you're hired to do that. And that's quite a long time to be in one place, for three years, at Eddie Condon's. That's quite a long time.

MR: When you make recordings these days, how long do you usually get in the studio to do a record?

BG: Well it takes us about two or three days maybe to make one record. Sometimes you can make one in one day, sometimes it takes two or three days. A lot of musicians shuffling back and forth and you have to wait for them, some of them are busy on the one day and you have to come in the next day. But all and all it's quite — especially with making CDs — it's quite a lot of work to do that because it takes about two or three days. On the Marty Grosz albums that I've made we usually take about two days on those.

MR: Because you can fit a lot of music on CDs as opposed to — records used to get about twenty minutes. You have also recorded with a whole number of people, including Leon Redbone. What was that like?

BG: Well the first time met Leon Redbone was in Eddie Condon's, I was playing there and he was looking for a clarinet player. And he sent in a fellow named Tom Waits, who

probably you are familiar with. So he was at the bar and I was playing the clarinet and I knew he was coming in, I knew somebody was coming in to hear me play so I said, "Mr. Waits, how do you do?" And he said, "I'm with Leon Redbone's entourage." So he had a couple of guys there. Leon wasn't there. And Leon said that he did hire me. We were supposed to go to Cleveland and I got a good word from Tom Waits, and everybody else was there. So the next day I left for Cleveland, Ohio, and I went in the backstage dressing room and Leon was fooling around with the guitar and I was fooling around with the clarinet, and he said, "Let's do it." So we went out and I spent an association with him for 17 years.

MR: I love that: "Let's do it." Just going out on stage, had no rehearsal.

BG: No rehearsal or anything. But I spent the next 17 years with him, and recorded about five or six albums with him.

MR: He's got such a unique — what's he like as a person?

BG: He's a very nice person. And he's very nice to me. And we appeared on "The Tonight Show" on the Johnny Carson show four times in one year. And he always was nice to me. That's the reason I moved out to California, because I left New York, Leon and I were in a — I don't know if I should say — a plane crash together. We were in Allegheny Airlines going from Morgantown, West Virginia. We were playing at the University of West Virginia, and we were in a plane crash that crashed right after takeoff. And he was hurt and I was hurt and the best thing, we were in the hospital for about six weeks. And the best thing, that we survived it, there were a lot of people killed. And the best thing for me to do, the doctors said was go out to California. So I went out there and I've been out there ever since.

MR: Wow. You were just talking about how hot it is out there now.

BG: It is, it's very hot.

MR: That's interesting and I was also looking at this, you had quite an association with Rick Fay.

BG: Rick Fay, yes. I didn't get a chance to meet him until the last 10 or 15 years. I didn't know him before, but I got a chance to record with him and he's responsible for getting me on some records and things like that. Great tenor player and soprano and clarinetist.

MR: Where do you feel you fit in to the sound of your fellow clarinetists. Do you emulate anybody? Were you highly influenced by anybody besides Joe Marsala?

BG: I was highly influenced by Pee Wee Russell quite a bit. I always enjoyed his playing. And the type of playing that I really like to do myself is I used to work with Joe Marsala's wife, Adele Girard. She was a great jazz harpist. She was the first swing harpist to come along in the 1900s. Casper Reardon and a couple of others came along. But I used to just like to play with her and Joe and play together, two clarinets and jazz

harp, which is very nice, it has a very pretty sound. And that was probably some of the most fun I've ever had playing.

MR: Well speaking of that, I wanted to play name that tune with you. Does this tune sound [humms]— you know that tune, right?

BG: Yeah, I think I know it. You mean "Don't Let it End?"

MR: Yeah. I sang it pretty badly. Actually I have a thing I wanted you to listen to here. [audio interlude]

BG: You can hear the harp on there.

MR: Yeah. It must have been a pleasure to make this record.

BG: It was because it's something I always wanted to do and never had the chance to, and Adele said she'd come out of retirement to do it, so we had a great band in Los Angeles when we did this record. And it got a lot of awards too, a lot of awards.

MR: It's got a great write-up on it and I like the sound of the harp and the piano in there.

BG: Yes, the mixture is beautiful, yeah. Thank you.

MR: Nice. What's your playing schedule like these days. Do you work as much as you want? Do you turn down work?

BG: No I work as much as I want, yeah. I live in San Diego in kind of a sleepy little town and I have a job, I play there every Thursday through Sunday in a little club out there in LaJolla, and then I do my traveling and do my recording and I'm pretty well happy, and I've been married now for about 11 years, and I'm pretty well happy there.

MR: Great, good for you. Have you ever been in a musical situation where you said this is not for me?

BG: Oh yes, when you play with some what I call banjo bands or something like that, maybe where there's 15 banjos all playing at once, and a tuba player and a loud drummer, wearing straw hats and vests and arm garters, that's the kind of thing I don't go for too much.

MR: It's interesting you bring that up because we saw that at one of the L.A. festivals we went to, and it made me wonder about what had been happening with the Dixieland music and —

BG: Well that's what's happening to it.

MR: That's what's happened. It's become more of a show.

BG: Yes.

MR: Fifteen banjos hey?

BG: Fifteen banjos, a tuba and drums. All of them playing out of meter and a lot of them out of tune. I don't enjoy that. I don't take many of those jobs if I can help it.

MR: Well here's a hard question. When you're improvising, can you describe to me what's going on in your head?

BG: Well if you're playing a tune, say like "Rosetta" or something like that, written by Earl Hines and Walter Thor, I play the melody if I'm playing by myself, I play the melody the first chorus. I try to remember the melody, I try to play the melody most of the time on the first chorus. And then I would change into a jazz chorus and I would think ahead of time in my head, which chord progressions are coming up next. I know F is coming here and D7 is coming there and G7 is coming there — I have it all stored in my head I hope. And I improvise on those chord changes on the song. That's how I do it.

MR: Do you think that there are Bobby Gordon licks?

BG: I wouldn't say there are any Bobby Gordon licks, no. Stolen licks from Pee Wee Russell and Joe Marsala maybe.

MR: And then you try to make them your own, right?

BG: Yeah, right. Then they're mine.

MR: I think everybody has to steal from somewhere. And where do you go from here?

BG: Back to San Diego.

MR: Back home.

BG: Back to San Diego and to start my weekend job, then I'm playing with a group called Hal Smith's Roadrunners, and we're going to be, next month, a couple of weeks from now, two or three weeks from now we're going to be in Sun Valley Idaho playing a jazz festival up there, and I'm looking forward to that, then we go to Scottsdale and then Palm Springs. I'm playing a date with the Palm Springs Symphony Orchestra, and then I'm playing here and there and then doing some more recordings. I've just had three recordings come out that I'm on and I have more coming out, making more coming up.

MR: How does that work with jazz recording these days? You know downstairs they have a whole slew of CDs and many, many record labels. Do they call you? Or do you actively promote yourself to them?

BG: No actually what they do is they call you. The record companies call you or I, as a leader, I've had three albums out as a leader on my own and the record companies have called me. And I've hired the musicians to be on the record. And that's how it usually happens. If I'm making a record with Marty Grosz for instance, he would call me and then I would come to New York or if I was there at a certain time, and I would make the record with him. It's not anything where you're under contract with anybody or anything like that. It's just making the records with somebody, and we try to sell them to whoever we can.

MR: Do you ever hear about how many actual recordings are sold?

BG: No I never hear of that.

MR: You don't get that kind of information?

BG: We don't get that kind of information. Most of them are mail order albums. But we do get reviews and press clippings from the different newspapers and magazines. They

always send us those things. But as far as the recordings go, in this type of jazz, they're not exactly million sellers like that they have today. It would take a long time to ever get maybe to sell a hundred thousand records, fifty thousand records would take a long time in the kind of jazz that we're playing today.

MR: It seems like there's a small but enthusiastic core of jazz fans.

BG: Yes. Especially the type that come here to Chautauqua. And you'll see them in the audience tonight. And when there's an intermission they'll be out buying all the CDs because they're the type of people that are the only ones left anymore for this type of music. Maybe there's some young people coming up that like it, but it's going to take a long time to train them.

MR: To train them? See now there's a key word I think. How do you train a future audience?

BG: Well, I think that today's music from the 30s and the 20s is coming back stronger and stronger. I'm not saying the big bands. I don't think the big bands will ever come back. But I think the small group like Fats Waller's and his rhythm, and I'm surprised that some black guys don't form these type of bands like Fats Waller had in the 30s. Maybe they don't think it's right or something like that. But I know from experiences where I play, if we play something like "The Image of You" or an old Wingy Manone tune, and someone does a vocal on it, we get a very good response from the audience, which is a mostly younger audience. They've never heard these type of songs before. They're listening to the lyrics again, and the lyrics are I think what knocks them out. I think that's what they like. Because it makes them think well gee, what have I been missing you know? And I think that is the direction of jazz now.

MR: Yeah. That's an interesting thought. The lyrics and actual chord progressions in those days, well I supposed we can sound dated, but there seemed to be more of a craft to the songwriting.

BG: Yes. They are not just one chord, like they have one or two chords and like they have today. These tunes were, you know, Gershwin and Irving Berlin and these guys, they wrote some pretty songs with nice chord changes and I think it's the little melodies to them that please the younger generation's ear. I think that's what it is.

MR: What's it like performing overseas?

BG: I've been to Japan twice with The Orphan Newsboys and that is really an experience. If I had — I love to go to Japan because they're so, they just adore American music over there, so anything American that has to do with jazz, you know you're already set up as being a hero. And that's the way we're thought of over there and it's a very nice feeling. And the younger generation over there really is in to that kind of music too.

MR: Is the cost of living as expensive as I've heard?

BG: It is, it's very expensive to live over there. One bottle of beer was $10.

MR: Wouldn't do too much of that. Tell me about what inspired you to do an album about the music of Bing Crosby?

BG: Well when I lived in Chicago we used to have a little record club, fellows that I knew, and we'd get together at this guy's house. And we'd listen to the old Louis Armstrong records, the "Hot Five"s and the "Hot Seven"s and all of the things he made with Luis Russell. But also we got interested in Bing Crosby's singing because he had a very nice voice. And we used to like to listen to him in the early days, when he was with John Scott Trotter's orchestra, making recordings for Decca and before that, the other labels. And we enjoyed Bing's style of jazz. And we started listening to him, the old records, back in the 60s, and I've been listening to him in the 70s, 80s and 90s now, and I've built up quite a collection, and that's the reason we recorded this album, because we wanted to get young guys that were interested in playing Bing Crosby music or Bing Crosby songs. And I think, in my mind for instance, I always had it in the back of my mind that Bing would be a great guy to record later on, maybe now or do some of his stuff now, in a jazz vein. It's kind of like a tribute to him.

MR: Great. You've mentioned the "Hot Five" and "Hot Seven" a couple of times. What was it about those particular recordings that really were such milestones, in your eyes?

BG: In the first place they were called "race records" I guess they were called. They all sold a million records. Each copy that came out on 78s. And Louis Armstrong was just a genius of a cornet player on those records. That was just a recording band. They never played out in a club or anything like that. All they did was get together to record. And I think Louis Armstrong really showed the whole world, including today, everybody that's playing trumpet, Louis Armstrong had an influence on everybody, and especially at that time when he was 25 or 26 or 27 years old. He was just playing some marvelous stuff on there, I thought, along with his contemporaries, Johnny Dodds and Kid Ory and the other ones that were on the records with him.

MR: The sound of the instruments that come off those old 78s is interesting. The technology of the time kind of flavored what everything sounded like.

BG: Well they used to record in Hammond, Indiana I think and they had — for Gennett Records — back in the 20s. And there was a train that would go by every day, two or three times a day, so they had to stop recording when the train went by. They were in a little barn and everything shut down when the train went by and then they'd get back and start recording again.

MR: Oh, wow. I see you have worked with Keith Ingham. Am I pronouncing that right?

BG: That's right.

MR: Okay. He's done some arranging for you also?

BG: Yes, he did the Bing Crosby album, the arrangements on that. And then Hal Smith, myself and Keith had made some trio albums together.

MR: That takes a lot of piano playing, to do the trio thing, doesn't it?

BG: Yes it does. It takes a lot out of everybody to do that.

MR: But Benny Goodman kind of did all right with it.

BG: He could do it very nicely, yes.

MR: If you had — oh you probably can't answer this question, — but if you had a dream band that you could work with for a couple of months and go around the country, do you have specific guys you would pick out?

BG: Yeah, I would have, if they were still alive I would have some of the guys that are passed away now, but —

MR: Who would they be?

BG: Well I'd probably have Bobby Hackett or Jack Teagarden and Eddie Condon and Jess Stacy, George Wettling, Walter Page on bass maybe, and I'd have Pee Wee Russell and Joe Marsala as my alternate clarinet players whenever I couldn't make it.

MR: That would be something to send them in as subs for you.

BG: Yeah.

MR: Well that's great. Anything else you'd like to add that I haven't thought about here?

BG: No, I don't think so.

MR: I'll be interested to hear you play tonight. Have you ever been in a situation in these festivals where you don't know a tune?

BG: Oh on some of them I have. I've been at really slick festivals where they are playing some bebop and I'm not too familiar with that type of music and I've tried to play it, and I know the chord progressions but maybe the melody I didn't know. But I've been in situations like that yes.

MR: Now what will happen this evening as far as, I know you guys don't rehearse. Will there be a talk through if you're playing in an ensemble?

BG: No there'll just, maybe just in the beginning maybe Marty might say something that we're going to play this in this certain key and I've got the first chorus or you've got the second chorus. There's that. But usually it's just a free for all, everybody just goes around and everybody plays what they want to play.

MR: And there's a jazz etiquette I suppose, to be learned.

BG: Yes, there is.

MR: I don't know if they teach that in schools.

BG: I don't know about California, but when I was in New York the clarinet always used to take the second or third chorus, but in California the clarinet seems to take the first

chorus all the time and I got kind of instilled in that, so I usually wind up taking the first chorus.

MR: That's interesting. Well I want to thank you for joining us.

BG: Thank you very much.

MR: It's been a pleasure. And we'll be listening this evening. And I hope your most recent recordings sell a million.

BG: Well thank you very much.

MR: It's about time for that, don't you think?

BG: Yeah, I'd say.

MR: All right.